Happenings in Handmade

A CCI initiative

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TODA EMBROIDERY

Weaving with needles

The Todas, a pastoral tribe, live in villages near the Shola forests in the Nilgiris. The traditional Toda dress is a distinctive shawl, the *Putukuli*. Considered a grand garment, it is only worn for special occasions like visits to the temple, festivals and finally as a shroud. The *Putukuli* is worn by both sexes.



Toda embroidery, called *pohor/pukhoor*, meaning flower, has distinctive red and black (and occasionally blue) thread work in geometric designs on unbleached white cotton fabric. The women, who do the work, take their inspiration from nature and the colours symbolize the different stages of human life. The embroidery is done in continuous bands using darning stitch, done from the back of the fabric.



The warp and weft of the fabric are used as a grid to embroider. Some stitches are tightly held while others have loops of thread hanging as part of the design. The ‘Rabbit’s ears’ design is used at the ends of the fabric to stop the threads from unravelling. There is no reverse in a Toda embroidered piece, so neat is the work on both sides – a matter of great pride among the artisans.







Members of the community expressed dismay at a major brand's misuse of the term 'Toda embroidery' on a kurta tag, where the embroidery turned out to be a mere printed pattern rather than the authentic *pohor* embroidery, despite its protected Geographical Indication (GI) tag. Similarly, a 'Toda embroidered saree' sold online at a fraction of its authentic cost was found to be machine-made.

Cotton was used originally but the Todas now favour wool for its cost-efficiency and speed, crafting items like sarees and smaller articles for income. Despite being a proud heritage, the meticulous double-sided embroidery faces a decline due to waning interest among younger Todas and the community's small size. Efforts are crucial to safeguard and preserve this endangered cultural heritage.



Sources

https://ruralindiaonline.org/en/articles/copying-our-designs-is-not-correct/

"Needle-weaving" of the Todas of the Nilgiris by Evam Piljain Weidermann and Sunita Shahaney in "Asian Embroideries", a compilation of papers presented at a seminar, published by CCI in 2004